

Inspection of Lancashire local authority children's services

Inspection dates: 11 to 22 May 2026

Lead inspector: Rachel Fairhurst, His Majesty's Inspector

Judgement	Grade
The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families	Outstanding
The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection	Good
The experiences and progress of children in care	Good
The experiences and progress of care leavers	Outstanding

Since the last ILACS inspection in 2022, Lancashire County Council children's services has continued to strengthen the quality of services to children in most areas, and the experiences and progress for care leavers are outstanding. A strong senior leadership team demonstrates an unwavering commitment to continuous development, with children, care leavers and families at the heart of practice.

The local authority has sustained effective services for children in need of help and protection, and a child-centred family focused approach to strategic planning means that more children are being supported to remain safely at home or within their wider family networks. There has been an increase in foster homes for children, alongside a well-considered reduction in the number of children in care and improved permanence for children. There has been further investment in early help, strengthened workforce stability, the development of specialist teams providing targeted support and interventions and a strength-based, multi-disciplinary practice model has been embedded.

Support is provided at the right time and at the earliest opportunity for children and their families, ensuring their experience of help, protection and care is effective. Safeguarding responses have been strengthened, with an increased understanding of contextual safeguarding, online harm, thresholds and improved information-

sharing. Leaders have strong levels of oversight of front-line practice and have developed a stable, experienced and committed workforce to improve children's experiences. Corporate parents are well informed about service priorities, offering scrutiny, challenge and support to improve outcomes for children and their families.

What needs to improve?¹

- The recognition and reflection of the needs of young carers, including those receiving support from statutory children's services, in the child's assessments and plans. (Enabler: the workforce is equipped and effective, National Framework)
- The consistency and quality of plans and planning that are focused on addressing the immediate risk of harm. (outcome 2, national framework)
- The management oversight of children living in unregistered children's homes and those who have their liberty restricted through Deprivation of Liberty orders. (outcome 4, national framework)

The experiences and progress of children who need help and protection: good

1. Children and families can readily access a comprehensive range of early help services, in their local communities, through family hubs. Thresholds for targeted early help services are well understood and applied appropriately. Children get timely and proportionate support, and for many children, this support prevents their needs from escalating.
2. When children's needs increase, effective arrangements enable step up to social care for social work intervention from early help. Decision-making to identify when this is needed has been strengthened by the provision of additional social work oversight. Early help workers remain involved, providing continuity of relationships for children and their families for as long as necessary.
3. Thresholds for referral to children's social care are well understood by partners, and decisions made at the front door are proportionate and timely for the vast majority of children. Social workers screen contacts effectively, consider the history of the family and any previous referrals, appropriately assessing the risk of harm. Experienced managers provide clear oversight, ensuring effective and appropriate decision-making.
4. Workers demonstrate a good level of professional curiosity about children's lives, which enables them to identify risk and assess its impact. Written plans are developed directly with the family. However, these are not consistently

¹ The areas for improvement have been cross-referenced with the outcomes, enablers or principles in the [Children's Social Care: National Framework](#). This statutory guidance sets out the purpose, principles for practice and expected outcomes of children's social care.

explicit about what parents need to do to increase children's safety. Leaders know there is still more to do to embed consistency of approach to safety planning, following recent training to increase social workers' understanding, and the implementation of clearer guidance to support practice.

5. When safeguarding concerns are identified, multi-agency meetings are held swiftly. They include key partners and lead to effective decision-making to safeguard children. Child protection enquiries are thorough, with effective actions being taken to reduce harm to children.
6. The out-of-hours service responds appropriately to children's needs. Immediate action is taken when needed, including holding strategy discussions to manage risk effectively and improve children's situations. The use of a shared recording system enables effective communication and seamless handovers between the emergency duty team and day services.
7. Children's assessments are thorough, with consideration of the views of parents and extended family. The voice of the child is clearly evident and is informing assessments. Needs and risks are appropriately identified and well considered through the assessment process. This helps to ensure that children are receiving the right services to improve their circumstances. Management oversight is strong, and this ensures that interventions are proportionate and responsive for most children.
8. Initial child protection conferences are well attended by partners, include the parents and child's views and are chaired by experienced child protection conference chairs. The conferences, initial and review, are well recorded, including the rationale for decision-making and the multi-agency analysis of risk. These meetings inform proportionate and measured decisions. There is effective challenge and oversight from the conference chairs, and this ensures that plans progress and are held at the correct threshold.
9. Children are routinely seen and seen alone. Social workers make positive use of a range of strength-based tools to help their understanding of children's lives and to inform decisions regarding risk. Direct work is undertaken with cultural sensitivity and empathy. Social workers and practitioners are inclusive of hard-to-reach parents, such as those in custody or where family conflict has led to absent parents. Social workers are tenacious in attempts to contact parents who do not engage, including visits and the use of other trusted professionals.
10. Social workers use strong relationship-based practice to build trusting and enduring relationships with children and their families, including for disabled children. Practitioners work effectively within a multi-disciplinary team, enabling children to get the right help at the right time. This includes professionals who work with adults with mental health issues, substance misuse and those who are victims of, and those who perpetrate, domestic abuse. This multi-disciplinary approach helps to ensure that families benefit from the right type of intervention and support at the right time.

11. Child-in-need and child protection plans are comprehensive. Plans are regularly reviewed and include the child's voice and that of their parents or carers. Plans end at a time that is appropriate, either following a reduction in risk or an increase that requires escalation. Decision-making for children who need repeat episodes of child protection planning or an escalated response is undertaken in a timely way for the vast majority of children.
12. The response through the Public Law Outline has strengthened since the last inspection. Strong management oversight, timely meetings and improved quality of letters before proceedings ensure that family strengths are recognised and parents are clear about what needs to change to improve their child's safety. Parents are supported effectively through this process, with appropriate assessments undertaken. As a result, for most children, there is no drift and delay in responding to escalating risk.
13. There is mostly clear and effective management oversight and recording of decisions about children's lives. Workers spoken with stated that they feel that supervision, group supervision, including multi-disciplinary supervision, and informal reflective discussions with managers help to inform their practice with children and families. Records of supervision are capturing reflections and tracking actions for most children effectively, and this helps to ensure that plans progress well.
14. Disabled children are supported by skilled and caring practitioners. Social workers are creative in seeking all children's views using a variety of tools to support children's communication needs and to inform their plans.
15. Children who are privately fostered benefit from timely referrals and well-informed assessments. Workers undertake the necessary checks and provide thorough analysis about their care. Children living in these arrangements are regularly visited to monitor the continuing suitability of the arrangements.
16. The response to children who are aged 16 or 17 years who present as homeless has been strengthened since the last inspection. Children are offered advocacy and are consistently advised of their rights and entitlements, including to come into care if their home situation and family relationships make living at home not a viable option. Housing options are considered and ongoing contact is maintained, even when children refuse housing support at the point of initial contact.
17. Children with young carer responsibilities on a plan of support do not have the impact of their caring role, nor their needs and additional vulnerabilities, consistently reflected in their assessments or plans.
18. The response to allegations about professionals has been strengthened, and there has been an increase in local authority designated officer capacity to meet demand. Concerns are swift and managed effectively, with appropriate

information-sharing to manage allegations and identify the next steps to improve safety for children.

19. When children are at risk of exploitation, or have been missing, effective multi-agency systems are in place to ensure that prompt action is taken. Return home interviews have been strengthened and are used effectively to contribute to safety/trigger plans, and social work oversight ensures that outcomes meaningfully inform children's plans. Children and families benefit from specialist workers, undertaking child-centred interventions, which are reducing risk effectively.
20. When children are at risk of entering care through family breakdown, support and diversionary work are available. This includes flexible and adaptable short breaks, with targeted support and work with children and their families. This is a new model of support for children and their families. It is leading to examples of support for reunification or working with families and their networks to successfully support and stabilise the home environment.
21. There are appropriate systems in place that meet statutory guidance to identify children missing education and children who access elective home education. There is effective oversight of these children's education and wellbeing where they are known to children's social care, via their family support or social worker.

The experiences and progress of children in care: good

22. When children can no longer safely remain at home, they enter care at the appropriate time. Well-recorded management oversight supports these decisions, as it does for decisions to initiate care proceedings. Early consideration is given to a range of permanent care options. These include children returning home to parents or to extended family members when it is appropriate. Many children in care make strong progress and live in homes that meet their needs well.
23. Children are helped to achieve a sense of belonging and permanence. Possible plans are considered for children to stay with family members that are known to them and who understand their needs. This minimises disruption for children, while being cared for by familiar adults who share their culture and history. Children are supported to maintain their family identity, including lasting relationships with their brothers and sisters.
24. Reunification with parents is explored when this is realistic and in children's best interests. Placement with parents assessments are detailed and appropriately consider presenting risk, with the child's voice threaded throughout. Effective management oversight is in place, and these arrangements are appropriately reviewed. Legal orders are discharged when it is safe and appropriate to do so, and this ensures that children and families are not subject to social care involvement for longer than necessary.

25. The quality of assessments and plans of support for kinship carers is good. Carers are supported practically, emotionally and financially, and this includes those who secure a special guardianship order (SGO). The local authority is actively supporting children to be able to secure permanence within their families by ensuring there is no detriment to children and families. Support continues when permanence is secured through an SGO. This is supporting stability for children in a home that is helping to enhance their sense of identity and belonging.
26. When family arrangements are not possible, the vast majority of children live in stable and caring homes. There is a range of services that offer support to both children and their carers, particularly when they are under pressure, including the provision of therapeutic support. This supports the stability of children's placements and reduces the risk of them experiencing multiple moves.
27. When children move into foster or residential care, including those placed out of area, brothers and sisters are placed together whenever possible and family time is established so that children maintain their valued relationships.
28. A child-centred, family focused approach has resulted in more children remaining at home or living safely within their family networks. There has been an increase in registered children's homes and foster homes for children and an ongoing reduction in the use of unregistered homes through effective sufficiency planning. Despite this, there are a number of children, with complex needs, including disabled children, who are living in illegal, unregistered settings. Although active searches for suitable registered placements are ongoing, some of these children have been living in these arrangements for a considerable period of time. When children present as a risk to themselves or others, the local authority acts appropriately to safeguard them through inherent jurisdiction of the Court of Protection.
29. For most, but not all children, there has been effective management oversight of children's care in unregistered settings and deprivation of liberty. Enhanced safeguarding measures are in place, such as more frequent social work visits, multi-agency and care planning meetings and searches to identify registered and suitable provision. For a small number of children, the management oversight, including of the legal and wider administrative processes to monitor these arrangements effectively, has not been sufficiently robust.
30. Children's care plans are comprehensive, consider appropriate permanence options and include children's wishes and feelings; workers determine early the most appropriate plan. Health, care, social and enrichment needs are fully considered and met, including for disabled children and those children placed at a distance.
31. Accessible and effective services are in place to support children who have experienced harm to build resilience and recover from trauma. An impressive array of services, including therapeutic support and timely referrals by social

workers for specialist, targeted work, considers children's vulnerabilities. This includes separated migrant children, those at risk of going missing from care, those at risk of exploitation and others who have experienced parental substance misuse, domestic abuse and mental health issues. The risk to children in care is appropriately identified, analysed and responded to.

32. Children's plans are regularly monitored through timely reviews, led by consistent independent reviewing officers (IROs), who know their children well and visit them to gain their views. Parents, carers and children are also encouraged to participate in their review meetings. On occasion, children chair their own meetings. This helps to ensure that children and their families are held at the centre of decision-making and planning.
33. The fostering service has been strengthened significantly since the last inspection. There has been a substantial increase each year in the number of prospective carers making enquiries, and being assessed and subsequently approved, increasing choice for children of lasting homes. Assessments of carers are completed promptly, with a good-quality assurance process and senior management oversight. When approved, carers receive tailored support to ensure that they can safely care for children and meet their needs.
34. Plans for permanence through adoption, including fostering to adopt, are well considered for children who would benefit from such arrangements. There is determination by workers in finding adoptive families for children, and many children are securing legal permanence without delay. Adoption services are delivered effectively in partnership with the regional adoption agency (Adoption Lancashire Blackpool). Adopters have access to ongoing support through the adoption support team.
35. Skilled social workers spend quality time with children; they get to know them well and build strong and enduring relationships with them. They work creatively with children, including disabled children, at the child's pace. Records of these visits are beautifully written, with the child's voice at the very centre. The relationships that social workers have with children are a strength. These caring relationships give children much-needed stability and help them to feel heard and seen.
36. Most children are in well-matched, lasting homes. Carers are cognisant of children's needs, and these needs are met through culturally sensitive work by carers and social workers. These conversations with the social workers support and strengthen the child's cultural identity.
37. Unaccompanied, separated migrant children in Lancashire benefit from specialist, dedicated teams of social workers, who carefully consider their needs and experiences. Support is immediate and ongoing for these children as they become young adults, fully recognising and meeting their needs for care and independence.

38. Children in care, including those placed at a distance, are supported to increase and improve their educational attainments, with attendance supported by carers and joint working with the virtual school.
39. Children benefit from beautifully designed life-story books. This work is undertaken at the child's pace. Children also have access to a virtual memory box, which provides photos of activities and experiences children have participated in and people important to them. These are valuable for children both now and in the future should they wish to explore their early childhood experiences.
40. The lifelong links service is highly effective and impactful in helping children in care to make lifelong connections with family, professionals and carers with whom they have lost touch. As a result, children have an increased sense of belonging and understanding of their origins and an increased support network. The direct work undertaken with children and young people adds to this understanding and increases their knowledge of their origins and history. For most children and young people, connections are increased, improving their experiences, and there is a direct benefit to accessing this impressive and invaluable service.
41. Children in care in Lancashire told inspectors they feel listened to and looked after well. They feel supported by their social workers, IROs and foster carers. They have consistent social workers, which allows them to build lasting, trusting relationships.

The experiences and progress of care leavers: outstanding

42. Dedicated personal advisers (PAs) know their young people well, having been introduced to them in a timely way, allowing for meaningful and trusting relationships to develop when children leave care.
43. Joint working and planning, with children's social workers who know and understand their children's needs, leads to appropriately focused support at a crucial time of transition into adulthood. Children stated they feel secure, valued and listened to as a result, with care leavers experiencing positive levels of financial, practical and emotional support from those they view as trusted adults.
44. Children and young people, including disabled children, are prepared for adulthood and supported into independence at a time that is appropriate and at a pace that is right for their identified and assessed need. Joint working with adult services is in place, and plans for next steps are identified. The young person's voice is integral to planning, and this includes those who remain with carers through 'staying put' arrangements.
45. The vast majority of care leavers are living in appropriate accommodation of their choice. They live in suitable homes with targeted levels of support to meet

their needs, and this ensures an increased likelihood of success of maintaining long-term tenancies. This stability is further enhanced by the skilled facilitators of the 'house project', who share their lived experience of moving into their own accommodation, and this is supporting young people to develop confidence and independence skills and to form friendships.

46. The comprehensive local offer, co-produced with care leavers, offers a range of financial, practical and emotional support that benefits care leavers, making a positive difference to their experiences. Care leavers are encouraged to access support from the wellbeing hubs, which are central points that offer practical guidance, advice and emotional support. This is a service strength as it provides care leavers with immediate support and reduces social isolation, providing opportunities to participate in activities and events.
47. Detailed, aspirational and co-produced pathway plans explicitly contain the voice of the young person, and plans are led by their wishes, feelings and needs. Plans, which are reviewed regularly, ensure all relevant support and entitlements are in place. Successes and achievements are celebrated for care leavers, both individually by their PAs and as a council, with award ceremonies delivered with pride.
48. The support for unaccompanied asylum-seeking care leavers is strong. They benefit from specialist workers, ensuring their legal, social, cultural, emotional and physical needs are seamlessly met. They are sensitively supported to engage with the wellbeing hub to access therapeutic and mental health support to understand the impact of trauma and early life experiences. Their cultural backgrounds are understood, and they are supported to make connections in their local community and through the hubs and to develop friendships with other young people. The pathway plans are detailed to reflect their unique needs. Access to legal advice is well supported, as is the challenging and emotional experience and process of asylum claims.
49. The vulnerabilities and complexities of care leavers are exceptionally well understood by PAs. Care leavers who are at risk of exploitation receive a strong multi-agency response that reduces risks and supports positive change. Care leavers in custody or who require support with their mental health have their vulnerabilities recognised and responded to by their PAs. Care leavers who are parents are offered bespoke support to meet their needs, including support with nursery provision to enable employment or training opportunities. Pathway plans incorporate these additional vulnerabilities, anxieties, risks and needs, and appropriate referrals are made to specialist services providing timely multi-agency support, including for domestic abuse.
50. Care leavers' health needs are well supported by their PAs, who advocate strongly for those who have additional vulnerabilities and require specialist services to improve their mental health and wellbeing. Life-story work helps care leavers to understand the impact of trauma from their childhood and life experiences. PAs are aspirational for their care leavers and support them to

engage in education, employment and training opportunities. This is helping care leavers to develop their resilience and improve their life chances. Care leavers at risk of offending are provided with additional support to help them to improve their lifestyle and secure work, which they can and do sustain to support them to achieve their dreams.

51. The leaving care service has created an environment where the vast majority of young people want to keep in touch, including up to and after they reach 25. For the very small number who choose not to, a positive, celebratory letter is sent to them, recognising their achievements and ensuring they know how to access support in the future if they need it. If there are ongoing concerns or identified risks, PAs proactively engage and provide ongoing support.

The impact of leaders on social work practice with children and families: outstanding

52. Lancashire County Council has a confident and stable senior leadership team, led by an experienced and capable Director of Children's Services. This leadership team is ambitious for children and has made improvements to practice, management oversight and multi-agency working, and it continues to deliver good or better services for children, young people and their families.
53. The tragic events in Southport on 29 July 2024 have led to a strengthening of partnership working in Lancashire. Leaders have fully recognised the impact of trauma on the wider community, and learning has been embraced. Safeguarding responses have been strengthened through targeted workforce training, enhanced quality assurance and management oversight, leading to improved threshold decision-making. There has been an increased understanding of contextual safeguarding, online harm and improved information-sharing.
54. Enthusiastic, involved council leaders are well informed about the priorities and challenges within children's services, and they are committed to improving outcomes for children. Continuous financial investment in services has supported the redesign of services, such as early help and safeguarding, and has ensured that the model of social work practice meets the needs of the diverse and varied community of Lancashire and is well embedded.
55. Council leaders and elected members demonstrate strong corporate parenting responsibilities. Effective collaboration and consultation are used to inform and shape plans and have a significant impact on decision-making and service development. Through participation and providing a forum for seeking the views of children and young people, co-produced plans ensure that children are prioritised in the strategic vision, addressing the issues important to them. Plans are targeted towards identified areas of need and priority to ensure children's experiences are positive and they have the support needed to thrive. The experiences and views of parents are also well considered.

56. Comprehensive performance information provides elected members and council leaders with an effective line of sight to front-line practice. They apply appropriate scrutiny to ensure that services are accountable and that the impact of practice is challenged and supported. Council leaders are child focused and demonstrate a strong understanding of issues affecting children and young people. They take seriously their corporate parenting responsibilities to improve children's experiences.
57. There is evident investment in children's services, and children and young people are a priority across the council. Specialist teams have been developed, and these teams are delivering innovative and effective services for children, including edge of care support, contextual safeguarding, therapeutic interventions and early prevention. Following this significant investment, a large number of community-based family hubs are benefiting children and families by providing early, accessible support when they need it.
58. The model of social work practice is fully embedded ahead of the social care reforms, and this has ensured a strength-based approach that focuses consistently on children's and families' experiences. Co-location of adult services is now well embedded across the workforce, and the early wraparound support is having a positive impact on families.
59. The collective, strong safeguarding partnership has clear and shared strategic ambitions with high aspirations for children and a commitment to improving services. Relationships with partner agencies are mature and well functioning. Co-located multi-disciplinary teams, with adult workers available to jointly work and collaborate on delivering plans and interventions, exemplify the positive multi-agency approach. Specialist practitioners also provide support to other practitioners, which allows for a number of avenues to manage risk and complexity of need.
60. Leaders know themselves very well, celebrating areas of strength and addressing service challenges. They have clear, well-focused priorities and aligned plans. Lancashire is an outward-facing council, embracing external scrutiny, learning and improvement. A strong quality assurance framework enables leaders to better understand the narrative behind the data. Emerging themes from audits provide learning opportunities for individuals and enable targeted training and resources to address any areas for development, without delay.
61. The commitment that Lancashire children will be cared for in Lancashire, with the 'where our children live' model, has led to an increase in provision and support locally through effective and responsive sufficiency planning. Sufficiency of placements for children in care with complex needs remains an area of significant challenge, and the demand for such services is increasing. Leaders have a dynamic plan to expand capacity in response to mapping and responding to need, but there is more to do to secure permanent and suitable placements for all children.

62. Leaders have recognised the significance of the stability of a workforce as their greatest asset. They have created a stable and skilled workforce they are proud of and that benefits children and their families through experience and consistency. The quality of training and the targeted focus on implementing training into practice have resulted in confident and adept workers.
63. The workforce is ambitious and committed to affecting positive change for the lives of young people, children and their families. It is influenced by confident, caring, child-focused managers, who have created an environment that allows the time, space and resources to affect change.
64. Supervision is strong, and this supports management oversight of front-line practice. Group, individual and formal and informal opportunities for reflection and guidance enable exploration of good practice. The workforce benefits from this approach, and it reflected that this has a positive impact on practice and is increasing practitioner confidence across the service.
65. Recruitment has been significantly strengthened through initiatives and pathways into social work. Retention has been developed through structured training, development and progression opportunities, such as tailored and bespoke management and leadership training and coaching.
66. The workforce is overwhelmingly positive about the opportunities provided to it and the support and development it receives. The reduction in the use of agency workers and staff turnover consolidates the work undertaken in this area to stabilise the workforce and create a positive culture of staff health and wellbeing. Without exception, staff said they genuinely love working for Lancashire County Council.

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